INTERVIEW

"MY FILM HAS UNITED PUNJAB, NOT INCITED VIOLENCE"

For three years, all filmmaker HONEY TREHAN wanted was his sophomore film, better known as *Punjab '95*, to get a release. Stuck in an endless quagmire with the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC), Trehan and his producer, Ronnie Screwvala, finally decided to forgo a theatrical release and opted for the ZEE5 streaming platform, where a censor certificate is not mandated.

There, too, Trehan's dream was shortlived. Within just two days, the film was taken down in India. A few days later, the government invoked Section 69A of the Information Technology Act 2000, citing "sovereignty, integrity, defence of India" and "security of the state" to ban the film. ZEE5 blocked access to the film internationally, too.

However, in those 48 hours, Trehan's compelling, affecting film on human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalra's battle for justice and the subsequent investigation of his death by the CBI had found a life of its own, with pirated copies circulating on WhatsApp and Telegram channels, torrents and YouTube. In an interview with Deputy Editor SUHANI SINGH, Trehan talks about his own battle with the CBFC, one where, like Khalra, he refused to relent, and the impact his film continues to make. Excerpts:



Q. What made you want to shine a light on Jaswant Singh Khalra?

I was raised in Tarn Taran and lived there until I was in sixth standard. I have seen people in our extended family and neighbourhood go through this. I had heard of Khalraji as a kid, *woh* impression *reh jaata hai* (the impression stays). You grow up, you become a filmmaker and you find certain stories, and you think, why not do something that makes sense to Punjab? It is high time the state had some serious cinema that could open a dialogue. Khalraji is one of the greatest martyrs of Punjab in recent history. In my personal opinion, his sacrifice is as big as Bhagat Singh's. In fact, he was a great follower of his. If we have people like him, people who had such an inspiring life and journey, who lived so selflessly fighting for others, I felt his story should be known.

Q. Tell us about casting Diljit for the role.

In January 2021, I messaged Diljit Dosanjh asking, "*Paaji, kahaan ho* (brother, where are you)? America or India?" He said he was in India, but was leaving for America that very night. I told him to meet me in Mumbai for just half an hour. He was cutting it a bit too close to his flight, but he came. I told him I want to do a film on Punjab but set it after 1984 because people think nothing happened there after Operation Bluestar. Dosanjh said there were a few stories, but the one that should be made was on this guy called Khalra. "*Paaji, kya life rahi hui hogi unki, kitni badi*